

The Complete Q4 Calendar

Every date worth selling into, October 2026 through January 2027 Branches B1 · A resource guide from The Creative Strategist

How to use this

This is a menu, not a to-do list. There are more than sixty dates here. You are going to run three to five real campaigns and post on a handful of the light ones. That is a full quarter.

Every entry tells you three things: what the day is, who it is actually good for, and one thing you could do with it. If a date does not fit your business, skip it without guilt. A borrowed occasion reads as hollow and your regulars will feel it.

Three tiers, and they need different amounts of you:

Tier	What it takes	How many
Big moment	A real campaign: an offer, a flyer, a video, an email	Three to five, all quarter
Trend day	One post. A photo, two sentences, fifteen minutes	Three or four a month
Worth knowing	Context. You probably will not post, but it explains why your customers behave the way they do	Read once

Your anchor is Thanksgiving, Thursday November 26. Everyone in the workshop builds that one. It is 8 and a half weeks from the last Monday in September, so nobody is behind.

A note on accuracy

The fixed national and religious dates here are checked. The floating ones (third Saturday, second Monday, and so on) are calculated from their usual rule.

Most "national days" are informal. They are promoted by trade groups and registries rather than officially designated, and sources genuinely disagree about some of them. They are still useful, because the hashtag exists and people use it. But if you are going to build anything significant around one, search it the week before and confirm.

Where a date is unusually contested I have said so in the entry.

OCTOBER 2026

October is your warm-up. The stakes are low, which makes it the right month to find out what your audience actually responds to before November matters.

Date	Day	What it is	Tier
Oct 1	Thu	International Coffee Day	Trend
Oct 4	Sun	National Taco Day	Trend
Oct 14	Wed	National Dessert Day	Trend
Oct 16	Fri	National Boss's Day	Trend
Oct 17	Sat	Sweetest Day	Trend
Oct 24	Sat	United Nations Day	Worth knowing
Oct 29	Thu	National Cat Day	Trend
Oct 31	Sat	Halloween	Big moment

Halloween · Saturday, October 31

Good for: anything visual, anything for families with kids, anything you can theme without discounting.

The play: this is your test lab, not your money moment. Post four themed options and let people vote in the comments. You learn what your audience responds to four weeks before the stakes get high, and it costs you nothing. **Skip it if:** nothing you do is visual and your customers are other businesses.

International Coffee Day · Thursday, October 1

Cafés, bakeries, anyone with a morning ritual. One photo of the first cup of the day, two sentences about why you still love making it.

National Dessert Day · Wednesday, October 14

Bakers, restaurants, caterers. An easy excuse to show your best-looking product with no offer attached.

National Boss's Day · Friday, October 16

Gift shops, flowers, restaurants, B2B services. People genuinely shop for this one and most businesses forget it exists.

Sweetest Day · Saturday, October 17

Third Saturday of October. Sweets, flowers, salons, anything given as a small gesture. Strongest in the Midwest and Northeast, thinner elsewhere, so check whether your customers know it.

National Cat Day · Thursday, October 29

Not just for pet businesses. If you have a shop cat, this is the highest-engagement post you will make all month, and it sells nothing, which is exactly why it works.

NOVEMBER 2026

November is the month. Everything from here is real.

Date	Day	What it is	Tier
Nov 1	Sun	All Saints' Day	Worth knowing
Nov 3	Tue	National Sandwich Day	Trend
Nov 3	Tue	US Election Day	Worth knowing
Nov 8	Sun	Diwali	Big moment if you serve these families
Nov 11	Wed	Veterans Day	Big moment
Nov 13	Fri	World Kindness Day	Trend
Nov 17	Tue	National Entrepreneurs Day	Trend
Nov 23	Mon	National Espresso Day	Trend
Nov 26	Thu	Thanksgiving	Your anchor
Nov 27	Fri	Black Friday	Big moment
Nov 28	Sat	Small Business Saturday	Big moment
Nov 30	Mon	Cyber Monday	Big moment

Diwali · Sunday, November 8

The five-day festival runs November 6 to 10. If you serve South Asian families, this is a major gifting and hosting moment: sweets, clothing, gold, home goods, catering, cleaning services. Get the details right and start promoting in late October, because people prepare well ahead. **Skip it if:** it is genuinely not your community. But check before you assume.

Veterans Day · Wednesday, November 11

The play: something specific, generous and easy to claim. Not ten percent off. Something that costs you a little and means a lot. **Skip it if:** you cannot back it up. A hollow Veterans Day post is worse than silence.

National Entrepreneurs Day · Tuesday, November 17

Third Tuesday of November. **This one is about you.** Tell your own origin story. These posts consistently outperform product posts, because people buy from people.

National Espresso Day · Monday, November 23

Cafés, and it lands three days before Thanksgiving, which makes it a useful warm-up right when your audience is already thinking about hosting.

Thanksgiving · Thursday, November 26 · YOUR ANCHOR

Good for: every business, which is exactly why it is the anchor. **The play:** gratitude is the only message that works for every business type, in every industry, without a discount. You are not selling on Thanksgiving. You are thanking people, and you are setting up the four days that follow. **Why this one:** the message is universal, the emotion is real, and it feeds straight into the biggest shopping weekend of the year. Build this well and the next four moments are a re-skin, not a rebuild.

Black Friday · Friday, November 27

The play: do not try to out-discount Amazon. You will lose. Win on the thing they cannot do: you know your customer's name. A small, personal, limited offer beats a big impersonal one. "The first twenty orders get X" is real scarcity if you are capacity-limited, and most of you are. **Skip it if:** you are a premium service business where discounting damages what you have built. See the no-discount section at the end.

Small Business Saturday · Saturday, November 28

This is your day. Every business reading this. **The play:** the entire national conversation that day is about choosing local over big. You do not have to create the reason to buy from you, it is already in the air. You have to be findable. **Skip it if:** never. If you only run two moments this quarter, make them Thanksgiving and this one.

Cyber Monday · Monday, November 30

The play: the online twin of Black Friday. If anyone can buy from you without standing in front of you, this is your moment. Gift certificates work beautifully here for service businesses: revenue now, work in

January. **Skip it if:** everything happens in person and there is no online way to pay you.

DECEMBER 2026

December splits into three different customers: the gift buyer, the panic buyer, and the person already thinking about January.

Date	Day	What it is	Tier
Dec 1	Tue	Giving Tuesday	Big moment if you have a cause
Dec 4	Fri	National Cookie Day	Trend
Dec 4 to 12	Fri to Sat	Hanukkah	Big moment if you serve these families
Dec 5	Sat	International Volunteer Day	Worth knowing
Dec 8	Tue	National Brownie Day	Trend
Dec 10	Thu	Human Rights Day	Worth knowing
Dec 14	Mon	Green Monday and Free Shipping Day	Big moment if you ship
Dec 18	Fri	National Ugly Sweater Day	Trend
Dec 19	Sat	Super Saturday	Big moment
Dec 21	Mon	Winter Solstice	Worth knowing
Dec 24	Thu	Christmas Eve	Big moment, panic buyers
Dec 25	Fri	Christmas	Big moment
Dec 26	Sat	Boxing Day, and Kwanzaa begins	Worth knowing
Dec 31	Thu	New Year's Eve	Big moment

Giving Tuesday · Tuesday, December 1

The play: tie a purchase to a contribution, or just contribute and say so plainly. A running tally on a chalkboard by the register brings people back the next day to watch the number climb. **Skip it if:** you have no genuine cause connection. Manufacturing one for the day is transparent.

Hanukkah · Sundown Friday December 4 through Saturday December 12

Good for: any business serving Jewish families. Food, gifts, candles, photography, home goods, restaurants, and any service bought as a gift. **The play:** eight nights means eight days of gifting, a much longer window than one Christmas morning. Gifts are often smaller and given nightly, so a bundle of eight

small things at one price solves the whole problem in a single purchase. Start before December 4, because people shop ahead. **Note the calendar:** Hanukkah ends December 12 this year, almost two weeks before Christmas. That is a separate, earlier selling window, not a footnote on a Christmas post.

Green Monday and Free Shipping Day · Monday, December 14

Both land on the same day this year, which makes it a bigger deal than usual. The last big online buying day where shipping still comfortably beats Christmas. Most small businesses have never heard of it, which is exactly the opportunity: the inboxes are far less crowded than Cyber Monday. **The play:** one email that says only "order by Wednesday and it is under the tree."

National Ugly Sweater Day · Friday, December 18

Third Friday of December. Retail, salons, anywhere with a team and a camera. Pure personality, no offer needed. One of the easiest posts of the year.

Super Saturday · Saturday, December 19

The last Saturday before Christmas and the single biggest in-person shopping day of the season. **Badly underused by small businesses. The play:** these are panic buyers. They are not comparing and not negotiating, they want the problem solved today. Post one thing at 8am: your hours, that you have gifts ready to go, and that they can walk in. No discount, no design work.

Christmas · Friday, December 25

The money is made in the three weeks before, not on the day. **Two campaigns hide in here:** – **Gift buyers**, through December 20. They are planning, comparing, and want it to be right. – **Panic buyers**, December 21 to 24. Completely different person. They want it solved now. Gift cards and anything instant win this window outright.

Watch the calendar: Christmas is a Friday, so the last real shopping weekend is December 19 and 20.

Kwanzaa · December 26 through January 1

Seven days celebrating African American heritage, community and culture. If you serve these families, this is a week of gathering, gifting and food that runs right through the quiet period when nobody else is selling.

New Year's Eve · Thursday, December 31

The play: this is where you sell January, in December. Fitness, coaching, organising, beauty, education, financial services, home improvement. People buy the version of themselves they want to be next year.

Timing: start around December 26, when every competitor has stopped selling and the field is completely empty.

JANUARY 2027

The month everybody forgets to plan for, which is exactly why it is worth planning for. Your competitors go quiet on December 24 and do not come back until the middle of January.

Date	Day	What it is	Tier
Jan 1	Fri	New Year's Day, Kwanzaa ends	Big moment
Jan 6	Wed	Three Kings Day, Epiphany	Big moment in Latino and Caribbean communities
Jan 8	Fri	Quitter's Day	Trend, and useful
Jan 18	Mon	MLK Day , and Blue Monday	Big moment, handle with care
Jan 23	Sat	National Pie Day	Trend
Jan 24	Sun	National Compliment Day	Trend

New Year's Day · Friday, January 1

Fresh start energy is at its absolute peak and it decays fast. Whatever you are selling into January, your best window is the first ten days.

Three Kings Day, Epiphany · Wednesday, January 6

Genuinely important and widely missed. In Latino, Caribbean and many Catholic communities this is a major gift-giving day, in some families bigger than Christmas morning. Children leave grass for the camels on the night of the 5th. **Good for:** toys, gifts, bakeries (rosca de reyes), restaurants, party supplies, photography. **The play:** if you serve these families, treat January 6 as a second Christmas and stock for it. Almost nobody else in your market will. **Note:** the US Catholic church observes it on the first Sunday after January 1, which is January 3 in 2027, while Eastern Orthodox churches observe January 19. Know which your customers follow.

Quitter's Day · Friday, January 8

Second Friday of January, the day most people abandon their resolutions. Informal, but real. **Good for:** gyms, coaches, nutritionists, organisers, anyone selling a habit. **The play:** the opposite of what everyone else does. While competitors post motivation, you post permission: "most people quit today, here is how to start again smaller." It is the most honest post in the fitness calendar.

Handle with care. This is a day of service and reflection, not a sale. A "MLK Day Sale" reads badly and people will tell you so. **The play:** if you participate, participate genuinely: close, volunteer, contribute, or simply say something true and sell nothing. If that is not authentic for your business, post nothing at all. Silence is a perfectly respectable option. **Also:** the third Monday of January is informally called Blue Monday, supposedly the most depressing day of the year. The claim has no scientific basis and originated in a PR campaign. Use it lightly or not at all.

The filter: how to actually choose

Run every date on this list through four questions, and be honest on all four.

1. **Does my customer care about this date?** Not do I. Do they.
2. **Can I deliver if it works?** A campaign that sells more than you can make loses you a customer instead of winning one.
3. **Do I have the lead time?** Count backward from the date. If you need two weeks to make something and the date is ten days away, that date is not available to you.
4. **Is this authentically mine?** Borrowed occasions read as hollow.

Three to five big moments. Three or four trend days a month. Not everything.

Dates that beat every holiday on this list

The dates that work best are usually the ones nobody else is competing for.

- Your business anniversary
- The day you opened, or the day you went full time
- A local festival, parade or market
- Your town's school calendar, early release days, spring break, first day back
- A home game, a local team's season
- The seasonal peak that is specific to your trade

Write down three of these. They belong on your calendar before anything national does.

1.

2.

3.

If you cannot discount

If you are a premium or service business, discounting in Q4 does damage that follows you into next year. Every customer you win on a discount comes back next year expecting the discount. You have other moves:

- **Add instead of subtract.** Same price, more value. A bonus, a small gift, faster delivery, a handwritten note.
- **Bundle.** Two things together at a price that is fair but not cut.
- **Early access.** Your regulars go first. Costs you nothing, feels like a lot.
- **Close the door.** A limited number and a real deadline. Scarcity beats discount for premium brands, and if you are capacity-limited it is simply true.
- **Opt out loudly.** Some businesses have built real goodwill by publicly refusing to run a Black Friday sale and saying why. It works when it is genuinely who you are.

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